Praise of the Eight Tathāgatas

Aṣṭatathāgatastotra · Toh 1166 · Derge Tengyur
དཔེ་བཞིན་གཤེགས་པ་བར་ཆད་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

Praise of the Eight Tathāgatas, known in Sanskrit as Aṣṭa Tathāgata Stotra and in Tibetan as Dezhin Shekpa Gyé la Töpa, is a devotional hymn in verse to the eight buddhas of the Medicine Buddha tradition, and its closing line attributes its composition to the master Śāntarakṣita. It praises each buddha in turn, from the King of Marks, Svaraghoṣarāja, Suvarṇabhadravimala, Aśokottamaśrī, Dharmakīrtisāgaraghoṣa and Abhijñārāja to the Medicine Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, the King of Lapis Light, and ends with Śākyamuni, the King of the Śākyas. The greatest share of its verses is given to Bhaiṣajyaguru, who is praised, often in a repeated refrain, as the physician of the three worlds who heals the sickness of the three poisons, attachment, aversion and delusion, and who is depicted dark blue in color, holding a myrobalan fruit in his right hand and a bowl of medicinal nectar in his left. It is Toh 1166 in the Tengyur, where it is placed among the hymns of praise (stotra) that make up the Praises section.

In Sanskrit: aṣṭa tathāgata stotraḥ
In Tibetan: Praise of the Eight Tathāgatas.

Homage to all the Tathāgatas.

Upon the flowers of the major marks, blossoming and pure,
The fruit of the excellent minor marks has formed, a beautiful body
Which becomes a glory to whoever sees it, hears of it, or even recalls it:
To that King of Marks (Suparikīrtitanāmaśrīrāja) I pay homage.

Richly adorned with jewel, moon and lotus,
Exalted in knowledge through mastery of all that can be known,
Possessing a mind as profound as the ocean:
To Svaraghoṣarāja I pay homage.

Gleaming like gold from the Jambu River,
Blazing with a splendor greater than a thousand suns,
With a body like a stainless golden pillar:
To radiant Suvarṇabhadravimala I pay homage.

Who has passed beyond sorrow and found supreme bliss,
Who pacifies the torment of beings' suffering,
And has become the protector and glory of the six classes of beings:

To Aśokottamaśrī I pay homage.

Who with the great sound of the Dharma crushes opponents,
Who possesses a body as profound as the ocean,
And dispels without exception the three poisons of beings:
To Dharmakīrtisāgaraghoṣa I pay homage.

Whose intelligence in the Dharma is of a depth hard to fathom,
Who revels in the utterly pure expanse of reality (dharmadhātu),
And directly perceives all that can be known, without exception:
To Dharma Mind of Direct Knowledge (Abhijñārāja) I pay homage.

Supreme physician, who heals the sickness of beings,
Who possesses a body as clear as beryl
And liberates beings with the light of his body:
To that King of Physicians I pay homage.

The Blessed One, whose compassion is impartial toward all,
The mere hearing of whose name dispels the suffering of the lower realms,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru (the Medicine Buddha), who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Who like the sun dispels the darkness of ignorance,
Who like the moon dispels the burning torment of the afflictions,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Teacher of gods and humans, King of Physicians,
Blessed One, who gives refuge in the three worlds,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

You are the physician of the three worlds;
You cut attachment, aversion and delusion off at the root,
And firmly establish all sentient beings in happiness:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Who with the eye of wisdom beholds all beings,
And with the eye of compassion pervades all beings,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

For wind, bile, phlegm, their combination and the rest,
For the four elements when they have fallen into disorder,
The remedy for disease, the myrobalan, is in your right hand:
King of Physicians, to you I pay homage.

Whose body is dark blue in color, like a blue utpala lotus,
Who holds in the left hand an alms bowl of medicinal nectar,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Having forever abandoned oceans of faults,
Who has gone to the far shore of oceans of good qualities,
The Omniscient One, who has become the god of gods:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Who, through vast aspirations completely purified,
Works like a wish-fulfilling jewel for the benefit of others,
The Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, who dispels the sickness of the three poisons:
To Vaiḍūryaprabha I pay homage.

Who through skillful means and compassion was born into the Śākya clan,
And crushed the army of Māra, which no other could overcome,
Whose body is as beautiful as a golden Mount Meru:
To that King of the Śākyas (Śākyamuni) I pay homage.

This concludes the Praise of the Eight Tathāgatas, composed by the master Śāntarakṣita.

Translator's Notes

• The eight tathāgatas praised here are the eight Medicine Buddhas, and the text names several of them in shortened, metrical forms. The first is called King of Marks, a play on the marks of a buddha described in his verse, since the Tibetan word means both "mark" and "name"; his full name is Suparikīrtitanāmaśrīrāja. The sixth is called Dharma Mind of Direct Knowledge, a shortened form of the name usually abbreviated as Abhijñārāja. In the verse beginning "The Blessed One, whose compassion is impartial," the same Tibetan word means "name," as the context requires.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human

translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.